

THE THIRD SPACE

Business Plan

Community-Building Mobile App | Brooklyn & Manhattan, NYC

Prepared by: Samantha Aleman, Founder
macusamantha@gmail.com | 305.302.3953

May 2026 | Version 1.0 | CONFIDENTIAL

Submitted to: Brooklyn Public Library PowerUP 2026 Business Plan Competition

1. Executive Summary

NOTE: The Executive Summary is typically written last, after all other sections are complete. A placeholder is provided here.

⚠ TO BE COMPLETED: Write executive summary last — 1-2 paragraphs covering: what the business is, who it serves, the problem it solves, the revenue model, current status (prototype complete, PowerUP competitor), and funding intentions (seeking \$20,000 PowerUP prize + future seed funding to complete MVP development and launch in Brooklyn and Manhattan).

Key points to include when writing this section:

- The Third Space is a community-building mobile app that connects NYC residents through in-person interest-based gatherings at local small businesses — combating the urban loneliness epidemic
- Launching simultaneously in Brooklyn and Manhattan
- Revenue from venue partner monthly listing fees, per-event ticket splits, and future premium user subscriptions
- Figma prototype complete — seeking funding to build and launch MVP
- Competing in PowerUP 2026 — \$20,000 prize would fund initial development
- Founded by Samantha Aleman, Brooklyn-based entrepreneur with background in sales and business development

2. Business Description

2.1 Who We Are

The Third Space is an early-stage mobile app startup founded in Brooklyn, New York in 2026 by Samantha Aleman. The company is in the process of forming as an LLC under New York State.

2.2 What We Do

The Third Space is a community-building mobile app that connects New York City residents through curated, interest-based in-person gatherings hosted at local small businesses and venues. The platform is not a dating app, not a generic event ticketing platform, and not a passive social media feed. It is a friendship and community platform — one where the profile is the product, every user is ID-verified, and every feature is designed to make real human connection easier before, during, and after an event.

The name comes from sociologist Ray Oldenburg's concept of the 'third place' — the social space between home and work where community naturally forms. The Third Space digitizes the discovery of that place and the people in it.

2.3 Where We Operate

The Third Space launches simultaneously in Brooklyn and Manhattan — the two boroughs with the highest concentration of our target demographic (adults ages 18-40). Expansion to all five NYC boroughs is planned within 24 months of launch, followed by other major US cities.

2.4 Products & Services

The Third Space offers two distinct products serving two distinct customer types:

For Users (consumers):

- A free mobile app (iOS) with ID-verified profiles, interest-based event discovery, attendee previews, pre-event messaging, per-event group chats, and friend matching
- Premium membership tier (\$9.99/month — Phase 2): includes ability to host your own community events, priority RSVP access, enhanced profile features, and hosting revenue

For Venue Partners (businesses):

- Two free trial event listings — proof of value with zero commitment
- Paid monthly partner listing (\$50-\$150/month) — ongoing platform visibility and event hosting capability
- Access to a growing, engaged community of local residents actively looking for experiences

2.5 Legal Structure

The Third Space is being formed as a single-member LLC under New York State law. Filing is in process. Once formed, a trademark application for 'The Third Space' will be filed with the USPTO under Class 42 (technology services) and Class 41 (entertainment and social event services).

2.6 Intellectual Property

The app concept, brand identity, product design, user experience, and all associated documentation are proprietary. A completed Figma prototype exists. All developer and advisor engagements require signed NDAs before receiving access to any proprietary materials. Trademark filing is planned immediately upon LLC formation.

2.7 Current Status & Timeline

- Figma prototype: COMPLETE
- Business advisors engaged: Pace SBDC (Susan Gluck), BOC Women's Business Center (Hector Davis)
- PowerUP 2026 orientation: attended
- LLC filing: in progress
- Trademark search: in progress
- Developer recruitment: internship job description drafted, posting in progress
- Market research: in progress with Brooklyn Public Library research librarians
- MVP development: pending funding and developer onboarding
- Target launch: TBD — dependent on development timeline

2.8 Financing Requirements

The Third Space is seeking \$20,000 through the PowerUP 2026 Business Plan Competition. These funds will be allocated to:

⚠ TO BE COMPLETED: Add detailed budget breakdown once development cost estimates are confirmed — categories will include: app development, LLC and trademark filing, marketing and content creation, initial operating costs

3. Market Analysis

NOTE: This section requires primary and secondary research. Data points marked with [RESEARCH] are to be confirmed through library research and surveys.

3.1 Target Customer Analysis

Primary Target Customer: New York City residents ages 18-40, with a concentration in Brooklyn and Manhattan.

Demographic profile:

- Age range: 18-40 primary, 40-50 secondary
- Location: Brooklyn and Manhattan at launch — specifically neighborhoods with high young adult concentration (Williamsburg, Bushwick, Crown Heights, Bed-Stuy, Park Slope, Astoria, LES, East Village, Harlem)
- Brooklyn adults ages 25-44 represent 31.8% of the total borough population
- Brooklyn's largest single age group is 30-34 year olds — 241,331 people (9.12% of population)
- Median age in Brooklyn: 36.9 years — squarely in the target demographic
- 70.4% of Brooklyn residents are renters — indicating high transience and heightened loneliness risk

Psychographic profile — the target user is experiencing one or more of:

- Recent relocation to NYC — social network disrupted, actively seeking to build new connections
- Remote or hybrid work — the workplace no longer serves as a natural social connector
- Friend group thinning naturally in late 20s and 30s as people have less free time
- Desire for genuine in-person connection after years of digital-only interaction
- Active interest in specific hobbies and seeking others who share them
- Specific community seeking (LGBTQ+, creative, fitness, etc.)

⚠ TO BE COMPLETED: Add primary research data from library research and user surveys — specifically: number of NYC transplants per year in age 18-40 range, average time to build NYC friend group, survey results from target demographic on loneliness and app usage

3.2 Competitive Analysis

Competitor	What They Do	Their Weakness	Our Advantage
Meetup	Interest-based group events	Outdated, no social profile depth, anonymous — you arrive and leave as a stranger	Full verified profiles, pre/post event connection, friend matching, messaging
Bumble BFF	Friendship mode in a dating app	Under-maintained, users don't take it seriously, too close to dating app roots	Dedicated friendship platform only — users trust the environment
Eventbrite / Posh	Event ticketing platforms	Purely transactional — no profiles, no social layer, no community	Deep social layer: profiles, attendee lists, messaging, group chats

Timeleft / 222	Stranger dinner events	50%+ no-show rate, no profiles visible before or after, no reconnecting after	ID-verified profiles, see who's going before you sign up, reconnect after
Facebook Events	Event discovery via social graph	Passive, algorithm-driven, no structured friend-making, aging user base	Active, interest-driven, structured for making new friends — not just seeing existing ones

3.3 Industry Analysis

The Third Space operates across three converging industries — all of which are growing:

Social Networking Apps:

- Global social networking app market valued at \$94.19 billion in 2024
- Projected to grow to over \$1 trillion by 2035 at a 24.42% compound annual growth rate
- Adults ages 25-34 are the largest single segment of social app users — 31.44% of all active users globally

Friendship & Community Apps:

- Friendship apps are expanding faster than conventional dating platforms
- More than 75% of Gen Z and Millennial users report burnout from dating apps and are actively seeking in-person friendship alternatives
- 50% of young adult social app users say they use apps to meet friends — not for dating
- Bumble acquired Geneva specifically to build out community and events features — validating this market

The Experience Economy:

- Post-pandemic surge in demand for in-person experiences over digital interaction
- NYC small businesses actively seeking ways to fill seats and drive consistent community foot traffic
- The 'meet people IRL' trend among Gen Z and Millennials is well-documented across major publications

⚠ TO BE COMPLETED: Add research librarian data: NYC event attendance statistics, mobile app download trends in NYC, number of active small businesses in Brooklyn and Manhattan by category, additional market size data

4. SWOT Analysis

STRENGTHS • Profile-first design solves the core failure of every competitor • ID-verified users create trust and safety no other platform offers • Dual revenue model — venues AND users — from Day 1 • Figma prototype already complete • Brooklyn launch aligns with PowerUP competition and local community • Founder has direct sales experience — ideal for venue partner outreach • No dating app baggage — purely friendship/community positioning • Strong social media content opportunity — founder-led TikTok and Instagram	WEAKNESSES • No technical co-founder yet — developer recruitment in progress • Pre-revenue — no proven financial track record • App not yet built — relies on Figma prototype for demonstrations • Single founder — limited bandwidth • No existing user base to demonstrate traction • ID verification adds friction to onboarding — some users may drop off
OPPORTUNITIES • Loneliness epidemic declared by U.S. Surgeon General — massive cultural tailwind • Gen Z and Millennial burnout on dating apps creates direct demand • Remote work has eliminated workplace as social connector — gap is growing • NYC small businesses actively looking for foot traffic solutions • Social networking app market growing at 24.42% annually • PowerUP \$20,000 prize could fund MVP development entirely • No direct competitor serving this exact combination of features • Scalable to all five boroughs and other cities	THREATS • Well-funded competitors (Bumble, Meetup) could copy the model with more resources • Trademark conflict risk — 'The Third Space' name used by other businesses in other industries • Low event attendance or venue no-shows could harm early reputation • User safety incidents could damage trust (mitigated by ID verification) • App development delays if developer recruitment is slow • Economic downturn could reduce discretionary spending on events

5. Marketing Plan

5.1 Pre-Launch Marketing

- Create 'The Third Space' TikTok and Instagram accounts immediately — separate from founder's personal accounts
- Begin posting content NOW before the app is built: 'Building in public' content showing the process, the vision, the why
- Content strategy: founder-led videos explaining the loneliness problem, showing the Figma prototype features, interviewing people on the street about making friends in NYC

- Goal: build a waitlist and social following BEFORE launch so Day 1 has demand
- Hashtag strategy: #NYC #Brooklyn #MeetNewPeople #CommunityBuilding #ThirdSpace #LonelinessEpidemic
- In-person promotion: founder attends community events in Brooklyn and Manhattan to talk to target users directly

5.2 Launch Marketing

- Official app launch announcement across TikTok, Instagram, and local NYC media
- Neighborhood posters in Brooklyn and Manhattan — Williamsburg, Bushwick, Crown Heights, LES, East Village, Park Slope
- Founder-led street promotion: parks, community spaces, farmers markets
- Venue partner co-promotion: every partner venue promotes their Third Space events to their existing audience
- Referral program: users earn bonus points for referring friends who complete profiles and attend first events
- Targeted outreach to NYC community organizations, LGBTQ+ groups, fitness communities, and creative collectives

5.3 Ongoing Marketing

- Regular TikTok and Instagram content: event recaps, user stories (with permission), feature tutorials, founder updates
- Feature walkthrough videos: founder posts videos teaching users exactly how to get the most out of every app feature
- User-generated content: encourage attendees to post about their Third Space experiences
- Press outreach: pitch local Brooklyn and NYC media on the loneliness angle — strong human interest story
- Email newsletter to waitlist and registered users with upcoming events and platform updates
- Community partnerships: work with Brooklyn organizations, cultural centers, and local media

6. Pricing Strategy

The Third Space uses a multi-tier pricing model that keeps the platform accessible to users while generating recurring revenue from venue partners and premium subscribers.

Product / Service	Price	Notes
User app — basic access	FREE	Full app access with standard features — free forever

User app — premium membership	~\$9.99/month (TBD)	Hosting privileges, priority RSVP, enhanced features — Phase 2
Event ticket — user facing	Varies: \$0–\$50	Set by venue; platform takes a % cut; kept accessible — most events under \$30
Venue partner — trial period	FREE	First 2 events listed at no cost to demonstrate value
Venue partner — basic listing	\$50/month	Standard monthly partner listing
Venue partner — featured listing	\$100–\$150/month	Priority placement, enhanced visibility, analytics

Ticket revenue split between The Third Space and venue partners: exact percentage TBD — to be finalized based on advisor input. Principle: venue takes majority (75-85%), platform takes a booking fee (15-25%). Event costs are kept within an accessible range so as not to price out the target demographic.

7. Nuances of Running This Type of Business

- **CHICKEN-AND-EGG PROBLEM:** The app needs users to attract venues and venues to attract users. Solution: onboard venue partners first with the free trial offer before the app launches — so there are events ready on Day 1 when users download the app.
- **TRUST IS THE PRODUCT:** Safety and trust are not features — they are the entire foundation. If a single high-profile safety incident occurs in the early days, it could critically damage the platform's reputation. ID verification and moderation are non-negotiable from Day 1.
- **EVENT QUALITY OVER QUANTITY:** Ten well-attended, well-curated events with 15 people each is worth more than 100 events with 3 people each. Early focus must be on quality, attendance rates, and user experience — not just volume.
- **VENUE PARTNER RELATIONSHIPS ARE LONG-TERM SALES:** Each venue partner is a recurring revenue account. Founder must personally manage relationships, check in regularly, and ensure venues are seeing results. Churn kills the model.
- **MODERATION AT SCALE:** As the platform grows, moderating user profiles, photos, messages, and group chats becomes a significant operational challenge. Clear community guidelines, reporting tools, and moderation infrastructure must be in place before public launch.
- **GEOLOCATION DEPENDENCY:** The platform's value is inherently local and geographic. Growth must be concentrated in specific neighborhoods before expanding broadly — a dense core is more valuable than a sparse spread.
- **SEASONALITY:** Event attendance will likely peak in spring and fall in NYC and dip in winter and summer. Revenue model and event programming should account for seasonal variation.

8. Operations

8.1 How the Business Runs Day-to-Day

- Founder (Samantha Aleman) manages all operations in Year 1 — venue partner outreach, marketing, content creation, user support, and developer oversight
- Developer intern or contracted developer builds and maintains the app
- Venue partners manage their own event listings through the self-service portal
- Users manage their own profiles and event registrations — minimal customer service required
- Admin dashboard monitors reports, flags, and moderation queue

8.2 Venue Partner Onboarding Process

- Founder identifies target venues through neighborhood research, personal knowledge, and librarian data
- Outreach via in-person visit, email, or Instagram DM using the venue sales pitch script
- Venue signs a partner agreement (simple one-page contract) and NDA
- Venue creates their portal account and lists their first free event
- Founder supports venue through their first two events — attendance tracking, communication
- After two events: conversion conversation to paid monthly listing

8.3 Technology Infrastructure

The app is operated on cloud infrastructure (Firebase or AWS) with Stripe handling all payment processing. The founder has no server infrastructure to manage physically — all systems are cloud-based and scalable.

9. Risk Mitigation Plans

Risk 1: Low Initial User Attendance at Events

Risk: Early events have low attendance — venues are disappointed and don't convert to paid partners.

Mitigation strategy:

- Cap early event capacity at 10-15 people so that even modest attendance feels full and energetic
- Founder personally attends early events to ensure quality and gather direct user feedback
- Offer venues 3 free events instead of 2 during the first 90 days while the user base is being built

- Use social media to drive targeted sign-ups to specific events before they happen
- Build a pre-launch waitlist so Day 1 has an existing interested user pool to draw from

Risk 2: Safety Incident or Trust Violation

Risk: A user misuses the platform, leading to a safety incident that damages trust and reputation.

Mitigation strategy:

- ID verification required for all users before any access — removes anonymity entirely
- Message request system prevents unsolicited contact
- Block and report features available from Day 1
- Community guidelines clearly communicated at onboarding and enforced immediately
- Admin moderation team reviews reports within 24 hours
- Future Phase 2: SOS check-in feature for solo attendees

Risk 3: Development Delays or Developer Departure

Risk: Developer intern leaves mid-build or development takes significantly longer than expected.

Mitigation strategy:

- Functional Requirements Document completed and detailed before development begins — any developer can pick up where another left off
- Code documented and stored in version-controlled repository (GitHub) — founder retains access at all times
- Consider no-code MVP (Bubble or Lovable) as parallel track — faster to market, less developer-dependent
- Identify backup developer contacts through Upwork and Fiverr before starting — not relying on a single resource

10. Financial Plans

NOTE: Full financial projections are attached as a separate Excel spreadsheet per PowerUP requirements. This section provides the narrative overview.

⚠ TO BE COMPLETED: Complete financial narrative once projections spreadsheet is finalized — include: startup cost summary, how \$20,000 prize will be allocated, projected break-even timeline, Year 1 and Year 2 revenue projections

Revenue model summary:

- Primary Year 1 revenue: venue partner monthly listing fees. At 10 partners averaging \$75/month = \$750/month recurring by Month 6.

- Secondary Year 1 revenue: per-event platform booking fees on paid events
- Year 2 new revenue: premium user subscriptions at \$9.99/month — if 5% of 5,000 users convert = 250 subscribers = \$2,490/month
- Break-even analysis: TBD — depends on final development costs and operating expenses

11. Management

11.1 Founder — Samantha Aleman

Samantha Aleman is the sole founder of The Third Space, based in Brooklyn, New York. She brings the following relevant expertise and strengths to this venture:

- Professional background in Business Development and Sales — directly applicable to venue partner outreach, pitching, and relationship management
- Currently a BDR (Business Development Representative) with experience in SaaS and restaurant operations software — understands both the technology and the small business landscape
- Brooklyn resident — deep familiarity with the target market, the neighborhood landscape, and the cultural context of the problem being solved
- Content creation skills — experienced with TikTok and Instagram, owns a Canon EOS R50 for high-quality lifestyle content
- Entrepreneurial drive — simultaneously managing a full-time career while building this business, engaging multiple advisors, and progressing the concept from idea to prototype to business plan within months
- Network of business advisors — actively working with Pace SBDC and BOC Women's Business Center

11.2 Advisory Support

- Susan Gluck, MBA — Certified Business Advisor, Pace University SBDC — guiding business plan development, entity formation, and funding strategy
- Hector Davis — BOC Women's Business Center — advising on business strategy and operational planning
- Brooklyn Public Library PowerUP Program — providing business plan classes, mentorship, and competition framework
- City Bar Justice Center NELP — free small business legal clinic for LLC and trademark questions

11.3 Planned Team Additions

- Mobile App Developer Intern — recruitment in progress via university career centers; role posted through Pace SBDC network

- Future hires (post-funding): marketing coordinator, customer success / community manager, operations support

CONFIDENTIAL — The Third Space | Samantha Aleman | macusamantha@gmail.com | 305.302.3953 | Version 1.0 | May 2026
To be submitted to: Brooklyn Public Library Business & Career Center | PowerUP Business Plan Competition | August 14, 2026